Diamonds

Waylon Jennings (feat. Glen Campbell)

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Note: This is a guide to a piece of music, so there are no plot spoilers to manage. It covers the song's full backstory, meaning, and listening context.

Quick Take

"Diamonds" is a lost Waylon Jennings recording, cut on the night of December 28, 1978, that nobody heard for nearly half a century. Glen Campbell happened to stop by Waylon's studio that evening, the two legends laid down a rowdy, funky outlaw-country track in a single session, and then it vanished into the vault. Waylon's son, the Grammy-winning producer Shooter Jennings, reassembled it from three different session tapes and released it in June 2026 as the title track of an archival album. The verdict from the people who have heard it: it is a genuine gem, not a scraped-together curiosity. You get Waylon at his swaggering 1978 peak, a "phenomenal" guitar solo from one of the most underrated players in country music, and a song about a man promising to give up his wild ways for a love who has already slipped away. If you like outlaw country at all, this is worth forty minutes of your evening.

The Story Behind the Song

The origin is almost too good to be true. On a late December night in 1978, Glen Campbell dropped by the studio where Waylon was working, and the two of them cut "Diamonds" more or less on the spot, backed by members of Waylon's band, the Waylors. The session was produced by Waylon's longtime drummer and co-producer Richie Albright together with Tony Joe White, the swamp-rock songwriter behind "Polk Salad Annie" (which helps explain the track's loose, slightly funky feel).

Then it disappeared. The recording sat unreleased for roughly 47 years. When Shooter Jennings finally went digging through his father's tapes, the song nearly slipped past him because he could not place the guitar sound.

> *"This track eluded me... suddenly, upon listening to the whole thing, I realized Glen Campbell had stopped by the studio and they recorded this little gem on a late December night in 1978." — Shooter Jennings*

He found the pieces scattered across three separate session tapes and stitched them back together. That is why the credit reads "Waylon Jennings feat. Glen Campbell," and why both men are listed as the song's writers.

What It's About

Underneath the barroom energy, "Diamonds" is a sacrifice song. The narrator pledges to give up his outlaw habits for the woman he loves, including the line, "Give up my drinkin', fightin' in bars." He offers her everything he has, framed as diamonds and stars. The catch, and the ache of the song, is that none of it worked: she is gone, and the lyric keeps circling back to the same unanswered question, "where did ya' go?"

It is hard not to hear this against the real Waylon of 1978: deep in the substance struggles he would later write and talk about openly, and married since 1969 to Jessi Colter, the woman

widely credited with helping him through them. Some readings suggest the song may be about Colter herself. That connection gets a little stronger when you notice she appears on the finished album. Treat the Jessi Colter angle as an informed interpretation rather than a confirmed fact, but it fits the man and the moment.

The Sound

This is not a delicate ballad. Reviewers describe a two-tone bass beat, a very heavy bassline, and a rowdy, slightly funky late-'70s feel that sounds like it could have been cut in a smoky barroom. Waylon's vocal is growly and animated, more loose and playful than his usual controlled delivery. One critic even floated the theory that the unusually animated performance is exactly why Waylon shelved it at the time.

The centerpiece is Glen Campbell's guitar. He delivers what one outlet called a "phenomenal guitar solo" that sets the outlaw tone immediately. It is a good reminder that before he was a household name as a singer, Campbell was a member of the legendary Wrecking Crew session players and one of the most gifted country guitarists who ever lived. "Diamonds" is a rare chance to hear those two sides of country royalty, Waylon's grit and Campbell's polish, in the same room.

Where It Sits: Waylon in 1978 and the Outlaw Movement

Context matters here, because December 1978 was the absolute summit of Waylon's career. His album "I've Always Been Crazy" spent the last eight weeks of that year at No. 1 on Billboard's Top Country Albums chart, and its title track was the last of four consecutive No. 1 country singles. This was right after "Ol' Waylon" (1977) and the genre-defining "Wanted! The Outlaws" (1976), the first country album ever certified platinum. A man with that much chart success and that much material could afford to record a great song one night and simply never release it.

That run sits at the center of outlaw country, the early-1970s revolt against Nashville's slick, producer-controlled "Nashville Sound." Outlaw artists won the right to control their own records and blended folk's introspection, rock's rhythms, and traditional country. Waylon and Willie Nelson are its founding figures, alongside Johnny Cash, Kris Kristofferson, Merle Haggard, Jessi Colter, and others. PBS's American Masters flatly credits Waylon with starting the movement. The irony, and it is very Waylon, is that even at his peak he was sick of the label, recording "Don't You Think This Outlaw Bit's Done Got Out of Hand" and calling the whole thing a self-fulfilling prophecy.

What You Might Not Know

- "Diamonds" is the second installment in a planned multi-part series of unearthed Waylon recordings that Shooter Jennings is curating from his father's vault. It follows 2025's

"Songbird," which debuted at No. 6 on Billboard's Top Album Sales chart and drew praise from the New York Times, Rolling Stone, Billboard, and Variety.

- Shooter frames the two albums as a pair: "Songbird" was the emotional, ballad-heavy record, and "Diamonds" is the rowdier "younger man's album" about relationships and unrequited love. The 12-track set even folds in Jessi Colter, who appears on the song "I'm Tired."
- Shooter is not just a famous son trading on the name. He is a Grammy-winning producer who has worked on award-winning records for artists like Brandi Carlile and Tanya Tucker, and he describes opening his father's archive as a "life-altering event."
- He calls "Diamonds" "one of my favorite recordings that my dad ever made," and casts the whole project as restoring an honest picture of his father rather than cashing in.

> *"All he cared about was music. It wasn't about image, it wasn't about money, or anything beyond wanting to be great at music and play music." — Shooter Jennings, on his father*

- How to hear it: the title-track single came out June 22, 2026 (Father's Day weekend, announced during a CBS Sunday Morning appearance). The full album follows a deliberately old-school, collector-first rollout, with physical formats (LP, CD, cassette) and downloads arriving first and streaming about a month later. Most outlets report November 13 for physical and downloads and December 11 for streaming, via Son of Jessi / Thirty Tigers, though one source listed slightly different dates, so treat the exact days as reported rather than locked.

If You Liked This, Listen Next

- **Waylon Jennings, "Luckenbach, Texas (Back to the Basics of Love)" (1977) —** His signature crossover No. 1, recorded in the same late-'70s window. The definitive sound of peak Waylon.
- **Waylon Jennings, "Lonesome, On'ry and Mean" / "Are You Sure Hank Done It This Way" (1973) —** The rawer, mission-statement template that the more polished "Diamonds" grew out of.
- **Waylon Jennings & Willie Nelson, "Good Hearted Woman" (1976) —** The duet that proved Waylon-plus-a-friend was magic. A direct precedent for the Waylon and Campbell pairing.
- **Glen Campbell, "Wichita Lineman" / "Gentle on My Mind" (1967-68) —** Hear the other voice on "Diamonds" at his own peak. Smooth countrypolitan as a foil to Waylon's grit.
- **Johnny Cash, "Sunday Mornin' Comin' Down" —** Same outlaw-era weariness and authority, and it pairs Cash with songwriter Kris Kristofferson in one listen.
- **Kris Kristofferson, "Help Me Make It Through the Night" —** The songwriter's-songwriter strain of outlaw country. Quiet intimacy that contrasts Waylon's swagger.

Two natural rabbit holes from here: the "Waylon & Willie" duet album (also 1978) and the Highwaymen, the supergroup of Cash, Jennings, Nelson, and Kristofferson whose Jimmy Webb-

penned "Highwayman" hit No. 1 in 1985. "Diamonds" is one more entry in Waylon's long history of great collaborations.

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- "Waylon: An Autobiography" (1996), written with music journalist Lenny Kaye. A long oral history in Waylon's own voice, covering his roots as Buddy Holly's protege, the outlaw years, his drug battle, and his marriage to Jessi Colter. The primary-source way to hear the man tell it himself.
- "Waylon: An Intimate Portrait of an Outlaw" (2017), a documentary endorsed by Jessi Colter and the Jennings family.
- "They Called Us Outlaws" (2026), a brand-new 10-part docuseries made with the Country Music Hall of Fame and executive-produced by Jessi Colter, Ray Benson, and Jack Ingram. It is notable for including interviews with 17 artists who have since died. The timely 2026 companion to the "Diamonds" release.

And if the whole "lost recordings" idea hooks you, you are in good company. The "Diamonds" project sits in a respected lineage of vault releases: Johnny Cash's "Unearthed" box set, his "American" series finales, and "Out Among the Stars," plus the steady stream of posthumous music from Prince's vault. Legacy stewardship done right, which is exactly how the Waylon project has been received.

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